Foundational Doctrines

(Creed Cards)

Building on Historic Christian Truth

Purpose

Introduce disciples to the Creed Card tool as a way to build theological foundation through interactive discovery and discussion. This week launches an ongoing practice of wrestling with essential Christian beliefs.

Why This Matters

You can't build a house without a foundation. Creed Cards give us bite-sized, biblical truths rooted in 2,000 years of Christian history. These aren't optional beliefs—they're essentials that define what it means to follow Jesus.

Preparation (Before the Meeting)

Leaders:

- Access Creed Cards in the DNA Identity app
- Select 2-3 cards for tonight (see suggestions below)
- Have devices ready to display cards OR print front/back for each person
- Review the "flip methodology" so you can model it
- Prepare to explain what a creed is (see below)

Disciples:

- No preparation needed

Meeting Structure (90 minutes)

1. Opening: What Is a Creed? (10 minutes)

"When you hear the word 'creed,' what comes to mind?"

(Let them respond. Most won't know.)

Define it: "A creed is a statement of belief. The word comes from the Latin *credo*, which means 'I believe.' Throughout Christian history, the church has used creeds to say, 'These are the non-negotiables. These are the truths we stand on together.'"

- **The Apostles' Creed** (summarizes the gospel)
- **The Nicene Creed** (clarifies who Jesus is)
- **The five Solas of the Reformation** (grace alone, faith alone, Christ alone, Scripture alone, glory to God alone)

Why creeds matter:

1. **They protect us from false teaching**
    - When someone twists Scripture, creeds help us spot it
    - "That doesn't line up with what the church has believed for 2,000 years"
2. **They unite us across time and space**
    - Christians in Kenya, China, and Iowa believe the same core truths
    - We're part of a 2,000-year-old family
3. **They give us language to articulate our faith**
    - You can't defend what you can't define
    - "Always be prepared to give an answer for the hope that you have" (1 Peter 3:15)

Introduce Creed Cards:

"Creed Cards are a tool to help you learn and wrestle with these foundational truths. Each card focuses on one essential doctrine—one core belief rooted in Scripture and church history."

2. How to Use Creed Cards (10 minutes)

Step 1: DISCUSS (Before Flipping)

- Look at the front: the topic, Greek/Hebrew word, transliteration
- **Ask:** "What does this word mean to you?"
- Let everyone share what they think BEFORE seeing the definition
- This surfaces assumptions, confusion, and different perspectives

Step 2: DEFINE

- Flip the card and read the definition together
- Read the key Scripture
- Read the historical context

Step 3: DEEPEN

- Compare what you thought vs. what Scripture says
- Ask: "Does this align with what you believed? What surprises you?"
- Read the key Scripture in context (look up the passage, read surrounding verses)
- Find OTHER Scriptures that use the same word or concept

Step 4: DISCUSS

- Answer the reflection question on the card
- "How does this truth change the way you live?"

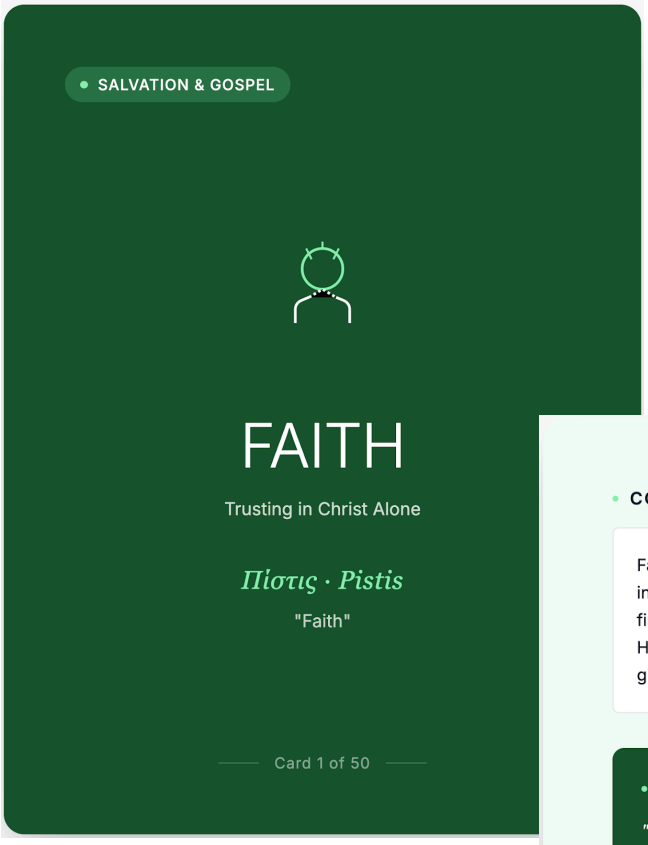
Step 5: DO IT AGAIN

- Creed Cards aren't one-and-done
- Come back to them regularly
- Memorize the key Scripture
- Review in the app throughout the week

3. Work Through 2-3 Creed Cards (60 minutes) Suggested Starter Cards:

1. **Faith** (Trusting in Christ Alone - *pistis*)
2. **Gospel** (Good News of Jesus)
3. **Grace** (Unmerited Favor - *charis*) *(Optional if time allows)*

EXAMPLE CARD 1: Faith (*pistis*) - 20-25 minutes

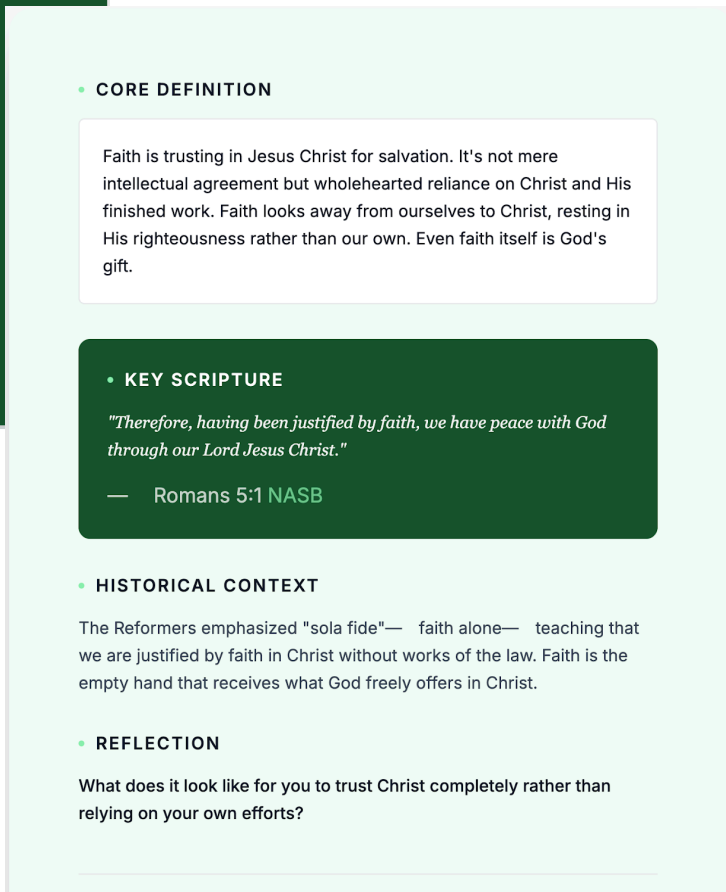


Step 1: DISCUSS (Before Flipping) - 5 minutes

Ask: "Before we look at the definition, what does **faith** mean to you?"

(Let them share. Don't correct yet—just listen.)

Follow-up: "The subtitle says 'trusting in Christ alone.' What does that phrase mean?"



Step 2: READ (After Flipping) - 3 minutes

Definition: "Faith is trusting in Jesus Christ for our salvation. It is not mere intellectual agreement, but confident reliance on Him. True faith results in transformation and obedience."

Key Scripture: "Therefore, having been justified by faith, we have peace with God through our Lord Jesus Christ." — Romans 5:1 NASB

Historical Context:

"The Reformers emphasized *sola fide* (faith alone)—we are saved by faith in Christ, not by our works. This was central to the Protestant Reformation."

Step 3: DEEPEN - 10 minutes

Compare: "How does this definition compare to what you said earlier?"

Dig into Scripture:

- "Let's look up Romans 5:1 and read verses 1-5 together."
- "What does Paul mean by 'justified by faith'?"

Word Study:

- "The Greek word *pistis* means faith, trust, belief."
- "Let's find another verse that uses this word."

Examples:

- John 3:16: "whoever believes (*pisteuō* - related to *pistis*) in Him"
- Ephesians 2:8-9: "by grace you have been saved through faith"
- Hebrews 11:1: "faith is the assurance of things hoped for"

Ask:

- "Why is it important that faith is more than just intellectual agreement?"
- "What's the difference between believing Jesus EXISTS vs. trusting Him with your life?"

Step 4: Discuss - 5 minutes

Reflection Question (on the card): "What does it look like for you to trust Christ completely rather than relying on your own efforts?"

(Give everyone 2-3 minutes to share their answer.)

CARD 2: Gospel - 20-25 minutes

(Repeat the same 4-step process)

Step 1: DISCUSS (Before Flipping)

- Front: **Gospel** - *Good News* - εὐαγγέλιον (*euangelion*)
- "What is the gospel? How would you explain it to someone?"

Step 2: READ (After Flipping)

- Definition, Key Scripture (1 Cor 15:3-4), Historical Context

Step 3: DEEPEN

- Read 1 Corinthians 15:1-8 in context
- Find other "gospel" verses (Romans 1:16, Mark 1:15)
- "Why is the resurrection essential to the gospel?"

Step 4: REFLECT

- "How would you explain the gospel to a 10-year-old? To a skeptic?"

Optional CARD 3: Grace (charis) - 15 minutes if time allows

(Same process, but move faster since they now understand the method)

4. Set Up Ongoing Practice (5 minutes)

Moving forward:

- "We'll work through one Creed Card every 2-3 weeks"
- "Between now and next meeting, review tonight's cards in the app"
- "Memorize the key Scripture from the **Faith** card (Romans 5:1)"

Challenge them:

- "This week, explain the gospel to someone outside this group using what we learned tonight"
- "Open the ARK app and read through 2 more Creed Cards on your own"

5. Closing Prayer (5 minutes)

Have one of your disciples pray out. They need to begin to practice this.

Creed Card Coaching Tips

Common Questions/Responses:

"I was taught differently in my church." → "That's okay. Let's look at Scripture together and see what it says. We're not here to bash other beliefs—we're here to discover truth."

"This seems too complicated." → "It's okay if you don't understand everything tonight. That's why we return to these cards multiple times. Let it sink in slowly."

"Why do we need to know Greek/Hebrew words?" → "Because English translations can sometimes miss nuances. Knowing the original word helps us understand what the authors meant."

Someone shares a false belief: → Don't shame them. Say: "I appreciate your honesty. Let's see what Scripture says and compare."

"How do I know which Creed Cards to study?" → "Start with the essentials: Faith, Gospel, Grace, Identity, Trinity, Holy Spirit. Then branch out based on questions that come up."

After the Meeting

Follow-Up:

- Text the group: "Which Creed Card challenged you most tonight?"
- Send a screenshot or link to the 2-3 cards you covered
- Remind them to review in the app this week